BIHAR

THE BIG DODGE

By Amitabh Srivastava

There was nothing unusual in Jitendra Kumar's annual asset declaration. The 44-year-old drug inspector with the Bihar health department had Rs 50,000 in cash deposits while his wife had a bit more, Rs 75,000. The couple together had a little over Rs 12 lakh in bank deposits. The assets seemed in sync with someone who had spent a decade in a government job and earned about Rs 8 lakh (after deductions) as annual salary. However, on June 25, when a team of vigilance sleuths raided his house in Patna, they found Rs 4.11 crore cash literally stuffed in the mattresses and in leather bags. The drug inspector also reportedly owns 27 properties.

The recovery of so much cash and assets has again exposed not just the dirty underbelly of Bihar's bureaucracy but also the limitations of the annual asset declaration exercise for public servants. It was in December 2010 that Bihar chief minister Nitish Kumar made it mandatory for public servants to declare their assets in the public domain every year. The move was seen as a big step towards curbing corruption and bringing in transparency. The details provided by employees were published on a government portal which was accessible to all, a first for any state. Nitish also made it mandatory for all ministers, including him, to declare their assets annually. Every state employee—around 640,000, including contractual staff—had to comply.

A top IPS officer says initially the CM's initiative did help stem the tidal wave of corruption but it lost its sting over the years with government officials filing undervalued or false asset declarations. They also found an easy way to dodge the system—never declare assets that could raise red flags. "Right now, the asset declarations have little value when there is no parallel legal structure to verify the claims," says the IPS officer. Indeed, by 2021-end, the state vigilance bureau had filed corruption cases against 4,517 public servants, the most recent high-profile one involving ex-Magadh University V-C Rajendra Prasad.

Experts say that the loopholes could be fixed, though. "All we need is a system to tally the asset declarations with the income-tax authorities. They have access to bank records, etc, no public servant can fudge their declarations to them. If there are discrepancies, we can question the source of funds," they say. Now, with the vigilance department lacking the manpower, they depend on operational intelligence to weed out wrongdoers. But that has its limits. Can Nitish's government provide the impetus to make asset declaration by its staff a foolproof way to curb corruption? ■



ANI

CASHIERED Vigilance officials with recovered cash at Jitendra Kumar's home in Patna, Jun. 25



MAHARASHTRA

THE TAP DANCE WAS A TANGO?

By Kiran D. Tare

How the mighty have fallen. When Sanjay Pandey, then acting Director General of Police (DGP) of Maharashtra, recommended an FIR against fellow IPS officer Rashmi Shukla in an illegal phone-tapping case in December 2021, he would have had little premonition that a similar scandal would catch up with him. The Enforcement Directorate on July 19 arrested Pandey in connection with the alleged illegal snooping on National Stock Exchange (NSE) employees, seen as potentially a key part of a mega scam. Pandey had retired just days ago as Mumbai police commissioner, after a 'blotless' career.

At the root of the charges is iSec